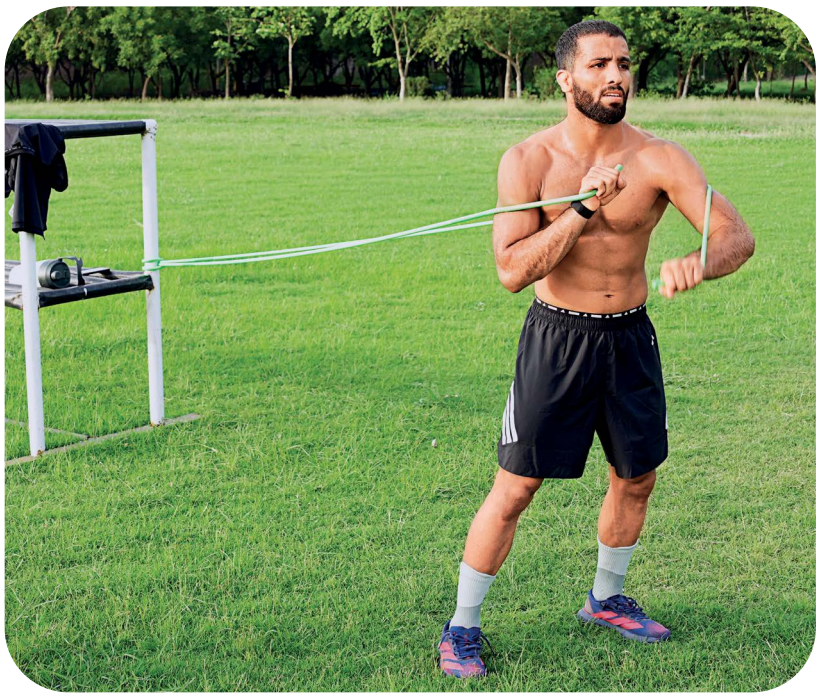
Though she started out with dreams of being a swimmer, Vennam's tenure in archery has landed her multiple Asiad golds and the Arjuna award. Coming soon: "As many medals as possible in Nagoya," she says, and maybe a Khel Ratna

the corporate world. But Jyothi took to archery easily. By the time she was 15, she was in the national senior team and participated in the 17th Asian Archery Championship at Tehran, winning a bronze (team event) in a breakthrough performance. For her achievements on the world stage, she was honoured with the Arjuna award in 2017.

As she continued to strike 10s on the range, Surekha aimed for academic laurels too, attending classes at KL University, Vijayawada, where she completed a B.Tech in computer science in 2017 and an MBA in 2019. These days, she spends six hours a day in target practice at the SAI centre in Sonipat, Haryana. She says,"My aim is to give my best performance and bag as many medals as possible, both in individual and team events at the Asian Games."

Despite her string of successes for over a decade now, the Vennam family harbours one disappointment: lack of a Khel Ratna, despite her three gold medals at the previous Asian Games. A similar tally in Nagoya will surely mean the award is hers. ■

—Prasad Nichenametla



SWEAT OF THE MAT

SUJEET KALKAL, 23

Sport: ***WRESTLING***

Discipline: 65kg Freestyle

Claim to fame

Gold at 2026 Asian Championships and 2025 U23 World Championships

In 2023, Sujeet Kalkal was in a strange predicament. He was gearing up for the Asian Games trials, well aware that it had little meaning. The 65 kg freestyle berth had already been handed to Tokyo Olympic medallist Bajrang Punia, uncontested. Kalkal moved court and continued training, but uncertainty derailed his efforts. His petition was dismissed, he lost the trials and eventually watched the quadrennial event on television. "I have now matured as a wrestler and as an individual. I focus on the things I can control and leave the rest to God," he says.

Kalkal has since won a bronze at the under-23 World Championships in 2024 and followed it up with a gold. He narrowly missed out on competing at the Paris Games but, in April this year, he landed the biggest title of his career—a gold at the Asian Championships. He pulled off convincing wins against Kazakhstan's Abdulmazhid Kudiev and Uzbekistan's Umidjon Jalolov, both former World Championship medallists. With his toughest rival, Iran's Rahman Mousa Amouzadkhalili, absent from the entry list, Kalkal is a favourite. "A few years ago, there was always fear creeping in during competitions," he says. "Today, I know what I need to do on the mat." ■

—Shail Desai